What is stopping Caplet from winning (16 Oct 2026)

Status: fact-checked version (16 Oct 2026). Eight fact-checkers re-opened the sources for about 650 claims; about 85 corrections are applied. References to `oct16/...` point to the evidence folder sent with this report.

How to read this. This is AI-generated research (Claude Code) for Team Caplet. It is not text to submit. It drafts no reflection, IPS sentence, pitch or Final Report prose: it says what is wrong, what the evidence is, and what a fix must achieve. If the team uses it, record that use in the AI-use log and the Final Report's Works Cited. All dates are Sydney time unless marked ET. It is based on the main repo at commit 2affd4c, the unmerged branch commit 412e9e3 (copy at `caplet-latest/`), the sibling analyses in `oct16/` and sources accessed on 16 Oct 2026. MODEL means a computer estimate, not a fact. UNVERIFIED means nobody could confirm it. The AI produced more than anyone can read (over 700,000 words of research in the repo, `oct16/lenses/L10_team_process.findings.json` TP-11); this is the short version. **Start with Part 1, section A:** the five decisions for the Sun 18 Oct meeting and the two Saturday jobs.

Hard deadlines (5:00 pm ET; `competition/official/2026_27/smapply_public_2026-10-14/deliverables.txt:22-25`; live page https://wghsinvcomp.smapply.us/res/p/deliverables/, accessed 16 Oct 2026). Sydney is on AEDT (UTC+11) since 4 Oct. US clocks change on Sun 1 Nov.

Deliverable	ET	Sydney	Caplet target (Sydney)
Trading Notes Analysis (TNA)	Fri 23 Oct 5:00 pm EDT	**Sat 24 Oct 08:00**	Thu 22 Oct evening
IPS, and trading ends	Fri 6 Nov 5:00 pm EST	**Sat 7 Nov 09:00**	Thu 5 Nov
Final Report instructions	Mon 9 Nov ("will be shared on November 9", deliverables.txt:51)	Mon 9 or Tue 10 Nov (time not stated)	-
Final Report + school letter	Fri 4 Dec 5:00 pm EST	**Sat 5 Dec 09:00**	Wed 2 Dec

Trading: "Official trading begins on September 28, 2026, and ends on November 6, 2026" (`smapply_public_2026-10-14/trading.txt:24`). The last possible trade is probably the 4:00 pm ET close on 6 Nov, about Sat 7 Nov 08:00 Sydney. That is an inference; Wharton's text gives only the date.

What changed since the 15 Oct brief (three things)

1. Commit 412e9e3 (16 Oct 01:24 UTC, not merged): a new team rule lets the AI put "[AI]" suggestions into the TNA, IPS and Final Report (`caplet-latest/CLAUDE.md:27-30`; `caplet-latest/COMPETITION.md:142-143`); an IPS number sheet on the 15 Oct curve; and 13 AI rewrites of IPS V5 (`caplet-latest/research/ips_numbers_2026-10/`).
2. The room under $300k for the bonds Caplet owns shrank to about $1.4k (about 0.05 percentage points of yield) on the 15 Oct close (Part 2, Box A).
3. The live FAQ changed between 14 and 16 Oct (Part 2, item 4).

Does 412e9e3 change our conclusions? Yes on three points: authorship risk, which numbers get quoted, and the risk that several [AI] suggestions bring in errors or wrong-basis figures, or cut scored content (Part 9 table). No on the main story: the strategy is sound, and the gaps are student ownership, honest certainty wording and the Final Report (`oct16/lenses/L12_premortem.findings.json` PM-17).

Five terms used below

- **Basis**: the method behind a number (which dates are priced, which interest rates are assumed).
- **Holdings basis**: pricing the bonds Caplet actually owns, at the dates they actually mature.
- **Percentage point**: a change in a yield, e.g. 5.10% to 5.00% is 0.1 percentage points. One basis point (bp) is 0.01 percentage points. Use "percentage points" in deliverables, never "bp".
- **MODEL**: a computer estimate from simulated futures. It is not a fact and has limits.
- **Floor**: the minimum facility contribution Laura can announce in 2031 (held in IBTM). In deliverables, use the case's words "facility contribution" plus one plain word for the minimum (Part 14).

Part 1. The list: what is stopping us from winning

Ranking rule. (1) Hard gates that can void a deliverable: notes copied exactly from filled orders, title-page names "the same as what was submitted with your official roster", the contact ban, permitted securities. (2) Decisions that unblock other work: the [AI]-rule vote, the ladder basis, the coupon-risk option. (3) Work only students can do: reflections, the IPS, the journal. (4) Everything else.

Format. Each item gives the instruction, why, the Sydney due date, the owner role, the "done when" test and where it is explained. **V** = needs a whole-team vote. Tags: **[new]** = new since 15 Oct; **[open N]** = still open from item N of the 15 Oct brief (`oct14/final.md`). Ray is named only where a rule fixes the job: only Ray trades (team rule, `START_HERE.md:28`), and the leader submits (Wharton rule: the team leader is responsible for "submitting team deliverables through SurveyMonkey Apply", Rules & Roles, accessed 16 Oct 2026). Roles are listed in Part 13. No role has more than three items this week.

A. This weekend (Sat 17 - Sun 18 Oct)

The Sun 18 Oct meeting: five decisions, in this order. Everything else waits until after the TNA is submitted. Two AI schedules disagree (15 Oct brief: picks Mon 19 Oct, vote set B Tue 27 Oct; the 16 Oct team lens: Sun 18 and Sun 25). This report uses Sun 18 Oct and **Tue 27 Oct** (`oct16/lenses/L10_team_process.findings.json` V-02).

1. **V. Vote on what [AI] suggestions may contain, before any is accepted.** [new]
   - Why: one person set the 16 Oct rule, and no team vote is recorded. It affects all six. The fix is a 10-minute vote. Wharton: "AI-generated work may not be submitted as your own" (Rules & Roles); students "must use their voice and words" (AI policy page); Creativity scores "an authentic team voice" (deliverables.txt:59). The IPS bans "formal citations" (`2026_WGY_Investment_Policy-FINAL.txt:123`), so an AI sentence in the IPS cannot be cited where it is judged.
   - Read aloud before voting: the Wharton AI text, the start of the Creativity criterion, and IPS line 123.
   - Due: Sun 18 Oct. Owner: whole team (lead chairs).
   - Done when: one rule is written down with the vote, and copied word for word the same day into START_HERE.md, CLAUDE.md and COMPETITION.md (they now disagree: `caplet-latest/START_HERE.md:26` vs `caplet-latest/CLAUDE.md:27-30`). The rule says what goes in the Works Cited: all AI use, not only "accepted AI wording" (Part 11).
   - See Part 11.
2. **V. Pick the three TNA trades and name one student author for each reflection.** [open 15-16]
   - Why: the 14 Oct export has zero reflection words (`team/google_drive/ips_report/04_trading_note_reflection.md`; `06_trading_note_reflection_deliverables.md`). The suggested picks are IBTR, IBTM and VT, "team decides" (`COMPETITION.md:110`).
   - Due: Sun 18 Oct. Owner: whole team.
   - Done when: three picks, three different authors. If a pick has no author by Mon 19 Oct, swap it for a trade a willing author can explain.
   - See Part 8.
3. **V. Name a deputy, set the submit time and fill the TNA roles.** [open 4]
   - Why: one person trades, commits, runs the routines, gets every alert and submits (TP-04). Roles are still blank (`team/google_drive/team_list.md:37-42`).
   - Due: Sun 18 Oct. Owner: whole team.
   - Done when: a deputy holds every final file. Each TNA step has a name: trade-log filler, ladder-figure owner, three authors, editor and word counter, paste checker, submitter and watcher. Internal submit is Thu 22 Oct evening.
   - See Part 13.
4. **V. Pick one ladder basis and one student who owns the number.** [open 11, 14]
   - Why: two figures for the same day are in the team's files ($294k and $298.6k). Both are right on their own basis (Part 2, box A). If the TNA and the IPS use different bases, they break "a clear and consistent investment strategy across all three" (`Laura_Gao_2026_Client_Profile.txt:161-162`).
   - Also decide: either write the IBTM and VT reflections so that no claim depends on the coupon-risk option still open (item 11), or pick the option's direction now (PM-05).
   - Due: Sun 18 Oct. Owner: rates analyst proposes; team votes.
   - Done when: one basis name is written beside every ladder figure. The team has decided "number or no number" for the IBTR reflection.

5. **Book the Tue 27 Oct meeting (vote set B) and give it an agenda.** [open 19]
   - Due: Sun 18 Oct. Owner: lead.
   - Done when: date, time and the item 11 list are in the team chat.

Saturday jobs (no meeting needed)

6. **Fix the public-repo and file problems.** [open 2-3, 5, 7, 28; new: fork]
   - Why: a team member's public fork was created 15 Oct 22:10 UTC. A public fork stays public when the parent goes private (GitHub docs, accessed 16 Oct 2026). The fork's account name shows a surname, next to a repo whose description names the school (GitHub API, accessed 16 Oct 2026). The WInS username is in COMPETITION.md, ops/routines/MONITOR.md and ops/routines/WATCHER.md (not reproduced here; INT-19). The fork holds only the 15 Oct snapshot, so the 16 Oct AI rewrites are only in the main repo.
   - Steps:
     1. The fork's owner deletes the fork (only they can).
     2. The repo owner makes the main repo private.
     3. With team approval, fix `COMPETITION.md:49`. It says "Laura is a fictional client." She is real: "While the client is real" (https://globalyouth.wharton.upenn.edu/competitions/investment-competition/, accessed 16 Oct 2026). Contact is banned (`smapply_public_2026-10-14/client.txt:23`).
     4. Delete "AI may fill a ticket up to Preview" (`caplet-latest/COMPETITION.md:193-194`).
     5. Correct the Feb-2037 coupon from 5.000% to 4.750% (`COMPETITION.md:181` vs WInS ID B-T-4.750-15022037 at `05_trading_note_reflection_wins_trading_notes.md:16`).
     6. Remove the WInS username from text files.
   - Due: Sat 17 Oct. Owner: fork owner; repo owner; rules/privacy lead.
   - Done when: no public copy that the team controls remains. All six have been told in person not to message, tag or follow Laura.
7. **Read the Week-One email and the logged-in Trading Details; open the TNA form without submitting.** [open 9]
   - Why: Rules & Roles says teams "must meet the required trading activity and portfolio management guidelines" (accessed 16 Oct 2026; `faqs.txt:76`). No public page defines this, and it is the only rule that could make an 11-trade, hold portfolio non-compliant (TNA-10). On SurveyMonkey Apply, "Mark as Complete" is not the same as submitting (https://help.surveymonkey.com/en/apply/faqs/application-faq/, accessed 16 Oct 2026). Wharton's own flow is UNVERIFIED.
   - Due: Sat 17 Oct. Owner: rules lead (email and Trading Details, read-only). Ray opens the TNA task with the deputy watching.
   - Done when: the exact words are copied into a private team note. The form's fields, counters and buttons are recorded.

B. TNA week (Mon 19 - Thu 22 Oct)

8. **Students write the three reflections, 100 words or fewer each.** [open 16]
   - Why: each must explain why, how it fits the strategy, and how it served the client's goals, funding or risk (`2026_WGY_Trading_Notes_Analysis-FINAL.txt:46-52`). None of the 11 filled notes mentions flexibility, liquidity or the residency (CLIENT-17), so the reflections must carry the client link.
   - Due: outline Mon 19, drafts Tue 20, final Wed 21 Oct. Owner: the three named authors; the editor counts words.
   - Done when: each passes the checklist in Part 8. No sentence says "locked", "secured", "guaranteed" or "promised". Any number is dated and names its basis.
9. **Start a dated decision log, and restate or retire trigger B.** [open 8]
   - Why: "hold" reads as discipline only if the checks are logged (UNIQ-12). Trigger B (sell VT, buy IBTM) was written on the old zero-coupon basis and never ratified. Its 14 Oct check date passed with no logged outcome (`rab/trades/october_trade.md:3-4, 18-20, 42`).
   - Due: start Sun 18 Oct; entries for 14, 15 and 20 Oct by Wed 21 Oct. Owner: rates analyst; historian.
   - Done when: each row has the date, rule, number with basis, and result ("hold"). Add no new notes to IBTR, IBTM or VT in WInS. WInS allows "Add/View Notes" (`team/google_drive/sheets/portfolio_and_trading_notes/wins_notes.csv:17`), so this needs care.
10. **Copy the notes character by character, submit Thu 22 Oct, screenshot the result.** [open 18]
    - Why: "Include each Trading Note exactly as it appears in WInS" and "Yes, we will verify this" (TNA instructions :44, :53). The notes are plain ASCII with straight quotes; Google Docs inserts curly quotes (TNA-13). IBTR is 294 characters, IBTM 292, VT 288.
    - How: copy from the WInS Trade Notes page and paste as plain text. Take identifiers from WInS Transaction History, not COMPETITION.md. Give WInS times in ET as WInS shows them; never convert them to Sydney time.
    - Due: Thu 22 Oct evening. Owner: paste checker (a second student); Ray submits; the deputy watches.
    - Done when: lengths match and the final status is screenshotted to the private Drive. Before pressing any application-wide button, check what it locks.

10b. **Ask the advisor to request the school letter now.** [open 10]

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- Why: it needs letterhead, an administrator's signature, the advisor's first and last name and every student's name (first and last name for the team leader) (`2
- Due: request by Fri 23 Oct; letter in hand Fri 20 Nov. Owner: advisor liaison.
- Done when: the names match the private roster note. The letter is never committed to the repo.
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C. Before the IPS (due Sat 7 Nov 09:00) and the trading freeze (probably about 08:00 the same morning)

11. **V. Vote set B (Tue 27 Oct): settle the rules the IPS will freeze.** [open 19; new: coupon option]
    - Why: after 6 Nov "Your team may not revise its investment strategy" (IPS instructions :73-74). The Final Report must test rules that already exist in the IPS (VER-L07-02).
    - Decide, in this order: 1. **Coupon-risk option.** Choose one of the 16 Oct number sheet's three options (`caplet-latest/research/ips_numbers_2026-10/IPS_number_sheet.md:49-54`): state the risk; keep Laura's half in the portfolio to 2042; or hold a $10-20k buffer from the 2028 deposit. A fourth option is a dedicated (cash-flow-matched) ladder. Test the choice on a joint bad case (stocks and yields down together), not only on independent draws (Part 7). 2. **One job list for Laura's kept half**, in priority order, and where it is held until the last payment. 3. **One certainty standard**, true for the bonds Caplet owns, with its assumptions. 4. **One floor definition**: what is held, what is quoted, how far it is rounded down, and what a ladder top-up does to it. 5. **One shortfall order** that ends inside the portfolio, through 2042. 6. **One principle for "responsible" and "appropriate flexibility".** 7. **The 2031 valuation date and any re-quote rule** for the two-year co-sponsor campaign. 8. **Whether WInS still "shows this allocation"** (`team/google_drive/ips_report/01_version_5.md:26`). If a choice changes the mix WInS mirrors, any order must fill before the IPS is submitted (Thu 5 Nov Sydney, so by the Wed 4 Nov 4:00 pm EST close = Thu 5 Nov 08:00 Sydney), or the IPS must say what the WInS book represents.
    - Due: Tue 27 Oct. Owner: whole team. The growth/risk analyst and rates analyst each bring a half-page options note.
    - Done when: each decision is logged in students' words, with who argued what, the vote and any dissent.
12. **Students write a fresh IPS from their own outline, with V5 and the [AI] list closed.** [open 20]
    - Why: the team's own comment calls V5 the "Best version that AI generated; We cannot submit as it is" (`01_version_5.md:36`). Three-word-phrase overlap with the AI exemplar fell from 95% (V1) to 19% (V5). That is what rewording looks like; it is not proof of student authorship (INT-02).
    - Due: outline Wed 28 Oct; draft Sat 31 Oct. Owner: each paragraph has a named student author.
    - Done when: the draft passes the IPS checklist in Part 9, and every author can defend every sentence aloud.
13. **Judge the 13 [AI] suggestions against the brief, not against word count.** [new]
    - Why: several add errors or delete scored content (Part 9 table). Accepting the favoured additions while rejecting the cuts takes V5 from 497 to about 528-542 words, over the 500 limit (JUDGE-V01).
    - Due: before the Wed 28 Oct outline. Owner: editor; rules lead.
    - Done when: each suggestion has a logged decision (accept the facts only, or reject). Nothing in the IPS contradicts a filled WInS note.
14. **Pass the IPS format gate.** [open 21]
    - Why: "Submissions that do not meet the requirements below will not be considered for semifinal selection" (IPS instructions :82-83). Limits: pitch maximum 50 words, IPS maximum 500, TNR 12, double-spaced, 1-inch margins, PDF, 5 MB; no graphics, charts, links, footnotes or formal citations (:107-123). The title page has the team name, names as "First Name, Last Initial" matching the official roster, and the WInS username (:84-100).

- Targets: pitch 45 words or fewer, IPS 470 or fewer on the stricter of two word counters, headings included. V5 is 47 + 497 words counted by spaces; a stricter counter gives over 500 (JUDGE-18). Check the exported PDF on Letter paper, because blank lines can push the two-page strategy section onto a third page, page 4 of the PDF (IPS-21; a font-metric estimate). Use the sample's two headings word for word (:135, :139).
- Due: check Wed 4 Nov; submit Thu 5 Nov. Owner: rules/format lead and one other student; Ray submits.
- Done when: two students have checked the PDF. The title page is copied from the private roster note. The PDF is never committed to the repo.

15. **Capture all WInS records after the IPS is submitted.** [open 13]
    - Why: the Final Report must "evaluate how effectively it implemented that strategy" (IPS instructions :75-77). The Trade Log is blank (`team/google_drive/sheets/portfolio_and_trading_notes/trade_log.csv`). Whether WInS stays open after the season is UNVERIFIED.
    - Due: Sat 7 Nov, after submission (the book is frozen), at the latest Sun 8 Nov. Owner: trade-log filler.
    - Done when: Order History, Transaction History, holdings, notes and Session Rules are saved privately, with the username and account number cropped out.
16. **Back-fill the real AI-use log for 1-16 Oct, and banner the false text.** [open 12, 24, 30]
    - Why: the log jumps from 30 Sep to a single 16 Oct row (`caplet-latest/docs/AI_USE.md:57-77`; the jump is between rows 76 and 77). Missing: V4 ("need to humanise"), V5, Tab 15, the 6 Oct AI notes, the 7 Oct AI browser click, routines and reviews. The ready-made disclosure says students "made all decisions, and wrote all submitted text" (`caplet-latest/docs/AI_USE.md:91`). Line 9 says language models are "strictly forbidden" from authoring prose, which the new rule contradicts.
    - Due: Sun 25 Oct. Owner: historian/AI-log keeper.
    - Done when: each row has the date, tool and model, task, output, and what students kept or rejected. Template sections 1-4 and `outputs/ai_use_log.jsonl` (242 mock rows) carry "DO NOT USE".

D. Start now for the Final Report (Sat 5 Dec 09:00)

17. **Back-fill the journal from dated records, then add to it weekly.** [open 23]
    - Why: Articulation scores "teamwork, communication, and learning ... growth and response to challenges" (deliverables.txt:58). The journal is about 390 words and stops at 7 Oct. It still has "[who argued what]" and "Outcome and reasons: [fill in]" (`team/google_drive/final_report.md:14-27`). Wharton says not to "invent teamwork and experiential stories" (Rules & Roles, accessed 16 Oct 2026). Last year's team doc asked for made-up stories (`team/google_drive/2025_knox_wharton.md:3827`).
    - Due: back-fill by Sun 25 Oct; then every Sunday. Owner: historian; every student checks their own entries.
    - Done when: every story traces to a chat, email, Doc history or WInS record, with AI's role stated. Unknowns stay blank.
18. **Pre-build every Final Report module that does not depend on the instructions.**
    - Why: the window is 25 days (Mon 9 Nov ET to Fri 4 Dec ET; last year it was 46 days, `oct16/research/KB_what_wins.md:134-136`). Last year 30 of 63 dated comments came in the final two days (FR-01). The only outline is for the abandoned plan (`deliverables/final_report_outline.md:5`).
    - Modules: - a criterion map (each phrase of each criterion, with a section and an owner); - one student-owned numbers sheet on the 6 Nov close and the holdings basis; - a 1 Jan 2033 reserve table; - good, middle and bad projections rebuilt by a student; - a list of every instrument named, each with a WInS listing screenshot; - an alternatives table (TIPS, corporate bonds, other governments' bonds, all-Treasury, more stocks); - weekly data from 7 Nov for charts.
    - Due: Mon 9 Nov. Owner: one student per module (Part 13).
    - Done when: on 10 Nov the team fits and edits existing material; it does not start writing.
19. **Banner or archive every stale file a student might copy from.** [open 30]
    - Why: STRIPS-era and old-plan numbers sit in files students will open. The 27-page Strategy Brief PDF has no superseded notice inside it. `deliverables/cosponsor_talking_points.md` has "$113k", "Laura keeps 20%" and matching. Seven rab decision memos have no banner (COH-15; FR-07).
    - Due: Mon 9 Nov. Owner: editor.
    - Done when: Final Report figures come only from the one dated numbers sheet.
20. **Prepare the co-sponsor excerpt as a facts checklist, and do the Taiwan reading yourselves.** [new]
    - Why: Creativity now scores communicating "investment uncertainty clearly and credibly to prospective co-sponsors" (deliverables.txt:59), and the case requires part of Laura's fundraising materials (case:123-124). The team's key funder source is misread (Part 6), and all its co-sponsor evidence is from the US.
    - Due: Taiwan reading list logged by Sun 15 Nov. Students draft the excerpt after the 9 Nov instructions; target Sun 22 Nov. Owner: client/co-sponsor lead (or two students).
    - Done when: the checklist in Part 6 is complete, every claim has a quote, page, date and scope, and no quote is invented for Laura.
21. **Plan for a page range that is a floor as well as a ceiling; full draft Sun 29 Nov; submit Wed 2 Dec.**
    - Why (FORECAST): 2022-23 set 9-12 pages ("will be disqualified"). 2023-24 set a main section of 5-8 pages, 10-13 pages in total excluding the Works Cited ("Reports that go over or under this range will not be reviewed") (https://globalyouth.wharton.upenn.edu/wp-json/wp/v2/pages/3768, accessed 16 Oct 2026). This year's numbers come on 9 Nov.
    - Owner: editor. Done when: two students check the PDF page count against the real range on 10 Nov and 29 Nov.

E. Ongoing and finale

22. **Every student owns one decision, one number and one section, and can defend them without a laptop.** [open 4]
    - Why: Wharton says "All team members must play a contributing role" and that name-only membership "is cheating" (FAQ, accessed 16 Oct 2026). At last year's semifinal, "Every team member must have a speaking role and briefly explain how they contributed value to the team" (2025-26 Semifinalists Next Steps PDF, accessed 16 Oct 2026; the 2026-27 format is UNVERIFIED).
    - Due: five-minute numbers check at the 27 Oct meeting; first full no-laptop test Sun 8 Nov; then every two weeks.
    - Done when: any student answers five questions aloud in 60 seconds with the right number, date and basis.
23. **Humans score first; outside readers score only.** [new]
    - Why: the AI drafted the self-scoresheet, AI judges score against it, and since 16 Oct AI may suggest the wording (`caplet-latest/docs/AI_USE.md:63`; `ops/routines/JUDGE.md:11, :24`). The scoresheet leaves out most of the Articulation criterion (`team/Winning Team Portrait and Scoresheet.md:103-107`). Last year an outside reader steered the story on 30 Oct and 11 Dec (`team/google_drive/2025_knox_wharton.md:3812, :3864`).
    - Owner: editor. Done when: two students and the outside reader mark each draft against the official criterion text before any AI judge runs. Outside readers give scores and questions, never sentences or story ideas.
24. **Each student reads the CFA Institute Asset Manager Code before 4 Dec.**
    - Why: "All teams should review the CFA Institute's Asset Manager Code and operate by these standards" (Rules & Roles, accessed 16 Oct 2026). No team file mentions it outside AI research. Its disclosure principles are a ready test for the team's own claims.
25. **Note the finale logistics; decide nothing unless selected.**
    - The Global Finale is on "April 29 & 30" 2027 (main page, accessed 16 Oct 2026). Knox Term 2 2027 starts Tue 27 Apr. Wharton does not fund travel, and finalists can attend virtually "if travel costs are prohibitive" (`faqs.txt:87`). A 9:00 am EDT session is 11:00 pm Sydney.

Part 2. Nuances and traps

Box A. The ladder number: one table, then "use this for that." All four figures use the same 15 Oct curve and the same ten $50,000 payments, valued on 1 Jan 2027 (`oct16/research/KB_verify/num/reconcile.py`, re-run 16 Oct on `caplet-latest/competition/official_market_data/daily-treasury-rates_2026-10.csv`).

15 Oct close	Forward rates to 1 Jan 2027	Yields unchanged to 1 Jan 2027
Priced to the payment dates (1 Jan 2033-2042)	$294,461, room $5,539 (19.0bp)	$295,246, room $4,754 (16.3bp)
Priced to the dates Caplet's holdings mature (15 Dec 2032-36; 15 Feb 2037; 15 May 2038; 15 Nov 2039/40/41)	$297,847, room $2,153 (7.4bp)	**$298,628, room $1,372 (4.7bp)**

- **Why they differ.** About $3.4k comes from the dates priced. Caplet's bonds mature 2 weeks to 10.5 months before each payment, and the bottom row assumes the cash waits earning nothing ($297,847 - $294,461 = $3,386). About $0.8k comes from forward vs unchanged rates ($298,628 - $297,847 = $781).
- **The number sheet's $294,453 / $5,547** is the payment-date, forward cell. `caplet-latest/research/ips_numbers_2026-10/ips_numbers.py:70-89` prices to `dt.date(y, 1, 1)`; see `results.json` "2026-10-15". The $8 gap to $294,461 comes from how the two scripts fill in between half-year points on the curve (the sheet interpolates discount factors; reconcile.py interpolates rates). The sheet's extra 1-, 2- and 3-month points make no difference. Lenses L05 and L08 print $298,624 / $1,376: the same basis, from a separate pricer (`scratchpad/indep_pricer.py`), so a few dollars apart.
- **Use this for that.**
  - For "what Caplet's WInS-listed ladder costs" (the IBTR note, the IPS, any certainty claim): **about $298.6k, room about $1.4k (about 0.05 percentage points), 15 Oct close, bonds Caplet owns, yields unchanged.** It assumes waiting cash earns nothing, so it is cautious. Use $297.8k / $2.2k (7.4bp) only if the claim says "forward".
  - The notes say waiting cash goes into "a short-term Treasury ETF" (`05_trading_note_reflection_wins_trading_notes.md:16-17`). If the plan names a home like that, earning short-term Treasury rates, the same holdings cost about $295.3k on the forward basis, room about $4.7k (3-month yield 4.28%; `oct16/verify/L01w/gap.py`). Use this figure only with that home named.
  - **$294k / $5.5k is right only as "the value of ten payments, priced to their own dates".** Caplet cannot buy that ladder on WInS. It equals Caplet's holdings only if the waiting cash earns today's forward rates.
- **Odds the ladder costs more than $300k on 1 Jan 2027 (MODEL).**
  - The sheet's "1 case in 3" (35%) belongs to the $294k basis: `ips_numbers.py:122` rescales the simulated 1 Jan 2027 costs so their median equals that headline.
  - On the holdings basis the odds are higher, roughly 4 to 5 in 10:
  - about 4 in 10 on the holdings basis (FR-04 verifier estimate; it does not say forward or unchanged);
  - 44-45% on the unchanged figure (L03, L08);
  - a rough check with the sheet's own rate volatility (1.0 percentage point a year) gives 34% with $5.5k of room and 46% with $1.4k.
  - One sentence for the team: "about 1 in 3 for an ideal ladder; close to 1 in 2 for the bonds Caplet owns (model)."
- **It moves fast.** Same holdings, yields-unchanged basis:
  - 6 Oct: $293,453 (23.0bp). `ops/routines/MONITOR.md:22` has $293,447 / 22.7bp: same basis. The 22.7bp is the exact yield fall that reaches $300k; the 23.0bp here is the room divided by the cost of a 0.01-point fall.
  - 14 Oct: $295,993 (13.9bp).
  - 15 Oct: $298,628 (4.7bp).
  - The move from 14 to 15 Oct alone was $2,635, more than the room left. So base the IBTR reflection and the IPS on the rule, not on a level. The rule: if the first deposit falls short, the 2028 deposit tops up the payments first, and the floor shrinks by the same amount (V5:24; `caplet-latest/research/ips_numbers_2026-10/IPS_number_sheet.md:14`).
- **Look-alike numbers.** The IBTR note's "about 0.2 percentage points" (6 Oct) and the sheet's "about 0.19 points" look equal, but they are on different bases. On the note's own basis the room fell from about 0.23 to about 0.05 points (L11-V02).
- **Also in the sheet:** results.json holds a third figure, $295,924 / $4,076 / 13.4bp (par yields used as zero rates). It is not the headline. The sheet header and the 16 Oct AI-log row say the cost was built on "WInS-listed holdings", but it is priced to payment dates (`IPS_number_sheet.md:5-6`; `caplet-latest/docs/AI_USE.md:77`).
- **Neither figure** counts coupon reinvestment or the 0.07% iBond fee.
- **Days over $300k in 2026:** 182 of 198 trading days to 15 Oct on the holdings basis; 173 of 198 on the payment-date basis (STRAT-01). Quote either figure only with its basis and end date.

Other traps

1. **Payments must be at least as safe as the range.** The model shows the 2033 gift inside the 2031 range in about 99 in 100 paths. But the portfolio alone fully funds the payments in only about 93 in 100 (`results.json`: p_gift_inside_range; p_exceeds_what_laura_kept 0.063; median uncovered about $3,150). The case says the range "must also protect" the payments (case:119-120). Both are MODEL figures that assume rates and stocks move independently; in the last year VT and the iBond ladder rose and fell together (correlation about +0.5; `IPS_number_sheet.md:69-70`). Never print a range-confidence figure without the payment figure beside it, and never quote "99.4%".
2. **The WInS book is a two-thirds copy.** It mirrors Laura's plan on 2 Jan 2028, scaled down to $300k (`team/google_drive/sheets/portfolio_and_trading_notes/portfolio.csv:2`; about 0.643 of the whole plan, $300k divided by about $467k, COH-06). Each WInS rung is about 0.65-0.68 of Laura's rung, so it pays about $32-34k, not $50k (STRAT-10; COH-06). A verifier who adds up the payment holdings sees about $197k (TNA-20). State the scale once, wherever a dollar amount appears.
3. **The filled notes fix the TNA's words.** The notes say "floor", "promised minimum", "ladder", "payout is not fixed" and "scaled to the model portfolio" (`05_trading_note_reflection_wins_trading_notes.md:14-24`). In each reflection, keep the note's own word. Link "floor" and "promised minimum" once (L11-V01).
4. **The live FAQ changed between 14 and 16 Oct.** It now reads "Investments permitted (for BOTH contributions, the IPS and Final Report):" and "Any stock from any exchange available on WInS." (https://wghsinvcomp.smapply.us/res/p/faqs/, accessed 16 Oct 2026). The 14 Oct copy said "(for BOTH contributions):" and "priced at $5 ... or higher" (`smapply_public_2026-10-14/faqs.txt:42-43`). So the permitted list now explicitly covers the IPS and Final Report plans, and the $5 wording is gone from the FAQ. Any team line that gives "stocks >= $5" as the current FAQ rule is out of date.
5. **Cash is not on the permitted list.** The list names stocks, ETFs and Government/Treasury bonds available on WInS. Name a WInS-listed fund for waiting cash. Never write "T-bills" or "cash" as part of Laura's plan (STRAT-11; COH-13).
6. **iBond ETFs do not promise a fixed amount.** iShares says "the Funds do not seek to return any predetermined amount", and they move to cash in their final months (https://www.ishares.com/us/products/350028/ishares-ibonds-dec-2036-term-treasury-etf, accessed 16 Oct 2026). Five of the ten rungs are iBond ETFs.
7. **TNA weight.** Rules & Roles says the Top 50 is chosen "based on the strength of their Investment Policy Statement (IPS) and Final Reports" (accessed 16 Oct 2026). But "Your Trading Notes Analysis, Investment Policy Statement and Final Report are evaluated" (deliverables.txt:27), and "Evaluators will consider the three deliverables together" (case:161). So time-box the TNA, but do not neglect it. Saying "the TNA does not count" would be false.
8. **Two volume rules.** The public rule is "no more than twice a security's current daily trading volume" (trading.txt:41). The team's copy of the WInS FAQ says "at most half" (`wins_notes.csv:14`, UNVERIFIED). If any trade happens, follow the stricter one.
9. **After the freeze, cash piles up.** About $1,539 of Treasury coupons should arrive on or just after 15 Nov (a Sunday in 2026; when WInS credits it is UNVERIFIED) (from the May-2038 bond and the three November bonds), plus iBond distributions (amounts UNVERIFIED). V5 says income is "reinvested in the holding that paid it", which cannot happen in a frozen book (FR-06). Explain it once in the Final Report.
10. **The next Fed decision lands while the IPS is being written.** The FOMC meets 27-28 Oct and 8-9 Dec 2026 (https://www.federalreserve.gov/monetarypolicy/fomccalendars.htm, accessed 16 Oct 2026). Re-price any figure after 28 Oct.
11. **"Only Ray trades" needs framing.** Rules & Roles makes all members responsible for "placing trades through the team's shared WInS account". The FAQ says trading "should be a team decision" (`faqs.txt:34`). Describe it as team decisions with one trader and one checker, and say why (TNA-19).
12. **Two "true stories" need care.** The 7 Oct mis-click was "an AI browser click" (`caplet-latest/COMPETITION.md:193`), so telling it truthfully discloses that AI operated WInS. And Wharton says "You are not expected to stay awake during the night to trade" (trading.txt:52), so a late-night story can read as ignoring advice. Build any story on the lesson, not the late night (PM-V02).
13. **Dates.** WInS shows ET in US format ("10/07/2026" is 7 Oct). Sydney is 15 hours ahead until Sun 1 Nov, then 16. Use month names, and use "placed" and "filled" precisely (COMM-15).

Part 3. How to be special but not stupid

Why structure alone will not stand out (INFERENCE). The case pushes competent teams toward one shape. Wharton's example trade note buys a Treasury ETF "as the residency funding date approaches" (TNA brief:36-39). The IPS brief asks how the mix will change "as future funding needs approach" (IPS brief:22-23). Most teams will submit a slow shift into bonds, a Monte Carlo "95%" and a percentile band (UNIQ-01). The strongest rivals will also buy Treasury ladders, and Wharton set a similar fixed-payment case in 2021-22 [N22]. So the edge must come from clarity, client insight, honest uncertainty and live defence, not from the idea itself (KB 3.3).

The test used (L04 section 4). Is it allowed by the rules? Does it serve Laura? Can a non-finance adult repeat it after one hearing? Is it literally true and defensible? What does it cost in team time? What is the risk of backfiring?

#	Differentiator	Test result	Where it goes	What it must achieve / caveat
K1	Each deposit has one main job: the first buys the payments, the second funds the facility	Allowed, serves Laura, one sentence. True only as a rule with an overflow step (room on 15 Oct was $1.4k-$5.5k), and only once Laura's half has one job (L04-V2). Cheap; low backfire if framed as a rule	Pitch; first IPS rule; IBTM and IBTR reflections; Final Report headline	State what happens if $300k is not enough in January. No dollar figure in the pitch
K2	Promise only what is already bought (bottom already bought, top set by a rule, capped)	True with care: IBTM's payout is not fixed, and in 2031 the floor is "bought, maturing Dec 2032", not "$145k owned"	IPS rule; Final Report co-sponsor text	Every dollar Laura names in 2031 has a dated holding behind it
K3	An honest uncertainty message for co-sponsors: three numbers (bought bottom, rule-set top, chance of reaching the top), dated, with a re-quote rule	The rubric clause is new this year (deliverables.txt:59). Sources re-checked on 16 Oct: numbers next to probability words improve understanding [B1]; keeping a promise is valued as much as beating it [GE]; seed money and announced lead gifts raise giving [V1][L1]; one US capital funder counts written pledges or cash [K2]. Limits: mostly US individual donors; the Kresge guide dates from 2011 and its challenge grant is "no longer the centerpiece"; the Taiwan grant rule covers one public programme (G1-01, G1-03)	Final Report (sources cited there); one principle in the IPS	Never promise to beat the top; state the evidence's limits
K4	Certainty measured by what is bought, with the leftover risks named	Depends on the protection vote (item 11). Must be literally true about coupon reinvestment	IPS; Final Report	The case's three asks (define, explain how evaluated, assumptions) answered in Caplet's terms
K5	Diversification by purpose, in Wharton's own words: one issuer for promised dollars, thousands of companies for money nobody has been promised	Wharton lists "risk characteristics, and funding purposes" as ways to diversify (trading.txt:49). Answers "92% one issuer" (VA-1)	IPS; VT reflection; Final Report	Students' own words; base any safety claim on market spreads, not ratings (G2-03)
K6	A priced answer to "why not corporate bonds?"	About $10.7k extra gross yield for the 2033-37 bonds, about $4.4k-$9.5k after credit-loss allowances (MODEL, 14-15 Oct data). Dated corporate iBond funds stop at Dec 2036, so 2038-42 cannot be matched, and individual corporate bonds are not permitted (G2-01, G2-02)	Final Report alternatives table; finale	Re-run on the 6 Nov close; name the downgrade-wave risk (G2-06). Not a reason to change the plan
K7	Why now	On Caplet's actual holdings, $300,000 could buy all ten payments on only 8.4% of trading days since 2000, and on none after 13 Jul 2007 until 23 Sep 2026 (MODEL). On the payment-date basis the figure is 10.3%, including 19 Oct 2023 (UNIQ-04)	Final Report; finale; at most a clause in the IPS	Use wording that is true on either basis ("rarely affordable since 2008"). Drop the "case timed to the curve" story
K8	The price of certainty against an all-Treasury baseline	Needs a re-run on WInS holdings (item 18)	Final Report	Shows caution as a measured choice
K9	The IPS as a short numbered rulebook in time order	Wharton: a strategy is "a set of rules and guidelines; a plan of attack" [D4]. Check word count and page fit	IPS	About six rules, each with its trigger
K10	Dated evidence of discipline and learning	Logged decisions not to trade; the IBTR test dated; true adaptation stories (sector-minimum myth traced to the primary page; stale prices led to a yield check; the IBTN mix-up; the 6 Oct email forced the move from STRIPS to iBonds) (journal:18-22; CLAUDE.md current status)	TNA (IBTR); Final Report Articulation	Each story needs who, when, and AI's role
K11	IBTM ready as the semifinal ETF case study	Past semifinals required "a case study of one stock or ETF" and banned new material [D1]. The 2027 format is UNVERIFIED	Final Report (so it is "not new")	Plain explanation of IBTM's two jobs, holdings, its final months in cash, and why its payout varies

Pick at most three signature ideas and use them in the same words in all three deliverables, because consistency with the IPS is scored (deliverables.txt:55). L04 suggests K1, K2 and K3. The rest are supporting evidence.

Ideas to avoid

Idea	Why to avoid
Themed picks for "client fit" (Taiwan ETF EWT, TSMC, gold GLD)	Not a hedge for costs in Taiwan dollars; breaks "promise only what is bought"; the strategy freezes on 6 Nov (journal:23; IPS brief:72-74)
A quant showcase (HAR model, optimisers, an "8-model suite"); company debt-to-equity or Sharpe ratios for a Treasury ladder	A 2025 semifinal judge warned against "hiding behind fancy terms and formulas" [N12]; a nine-stage quant pipeline stopped at the Top 50 (KB 3.2); stock metrics have no job here (notes&disc:270-271; TP-15)
Selling the "AI council" as a strength	Ownership and plagiarism risk; disclose it in Works Cited, never market it (INT-04, INT-07)
"Wharton timed the case PDF to the curve"	The designer's intent is UNVERIFIED. The first 2026 day under $300k was 10 Sep on the payment-date basis and 23 Sep on the holdings basis (UNIQ-04)
Biography details about Laura, quotes from her, or the case pull quote presented as hers	The pull quote is the case's words (CLAUDE.md:107); extra biography reads oddly for a real person (CLIENT-15)
Fundraising text in Chinese	Hard to verify; an AI translation would be AI work (INFERENCE)
Comic-style art in the written round	Images are banned in the IPS (IPS brief:123); Final Report format is UNVERIFIED until 9 Nov; AI art cannot be passed off as the team's own
"99 times in 100" or "99.4%" as a headline	Partly true by design (the cap stops the gift going above the top), and it looks like every team's Monte Carlo (UNIQ-06)
Australian branding or "first Australian" claims	No Australian team has made a Top 50 since 2021-22, and media "firsts" are often wrong (KB 5.2; R3 4.3); it does not serve Laura (UNIQ-19)
Talking about WInS gains or rank	"Your WInS standings have no impact on competition results" [X1]
A second metaphor layer, or untested names	"Root-and-Branch" is a chiefly British phrase meaning "complete or thorough", as in "a root and branch overhaul" [MW]; "caplet", "cap" and "floor" are interest-rate derivative words to a bond reader [WP] (UNIQ-14, COMM-18). Test the name on two outside adults and explain it once if kept
Reusing the old "$16k-22k" corporate saving	It is on the retired STRIPS basis and uses the all-maturity spread (G2-04)
Saying the uncertainty-words study sampled Taiwan	The open page thanks translators for China and Hong Kong; the full country list is behind a paywall (G1-06)

Part 4. What past competitions tell us

4.1 The funnel (KB 1.1)

Season (client)	Registered	Final reports	Top N	Finalists	Champion
2021-22 (Nichole Jordan)	not stated ("thousands of competing students")	nearly 1,300 [N1]	50	10	Sailing to Success (US) [W4]
2022-23 (Peter Wang Hjemdahl)	3,200 [N6]	1,400 [N6]	55	10	DMV's Finest (US)
2023-24 (Hilary Ash)	n/a	1,600+ [N8]	50	11	Spark Investments (US)
2024-25 (Ladi Ayoola)	5,000+ [N11]	1,800+ [N11]	50	10	BAM Investing (US)

Season (client)	Registered	Final reports	Top N	Finalists	Champion
2025-26 (Connor Barwin)	6,300+ [N14]	about 2,300; counter 2,339 [N14][W1]	49	11 [N15]	FigCapital (US)
2026-27 (Laura Gao)	not public	due Fri 4 Dec	50 "TBD" [W1]	"top 10" [W1]	finale "April 29 & 30" [W1]

The Top 50 has shrunk from 3.8% of final reports (2021-22) to 2.1% (2025-26). Only about 36-44% of registered teams submit a final report. Last year the Top 50 was announced 46 days after the deadline (27 Jan 2026) [N14].

4.2 How judging works

- **Criteria (verbatim, deliverables.txt:55-59).** Investment Strategy: "clear and creative investment thesis … disciplined planning across Laura's changing time horizons and cash-flow needs; uses appropriate diversification; and maintains consistency with the team's IPS". Client Knowledge: "circumstances, priorities, risk considerations, and residency goals … recommendations that can earn her confidence". Portfolio Analysis: "reasonable assumptions and projections to evaluate funding reliability, the facility contribution, and financial flexibility under varying market outcomes". Articulation: "teamwork, communication, and learning … research and decision-making process … growth and response to challenges". Creativity and Presentation: "authentic team voice; uses data effectively … communicates Laura's potential facility contribution and investment uncertainty clearly and credibly to prospective co-sponsors".
- **Which deliverables count.** Same quotes as Part 2, item 7 [W2]: treat the TNA as scored, with the IPS and Final Report carrying the cut. The TNA's weight is UNVERIFIED.
- **No weights, no feedback.** Wharton publishes no weights and gives "no individual feedback" (faqs.txt:78).
- **Who reads.** In 2025-26 the Top 50 was picked with "Wharton School student evaluators" and "a professional review panel of asset managers from Aberdeen Investments" [N14]. This year's main page says only "a panel of judges" [W1]. The 2025-26 semifinal used 15 judges, mostly Wharton alumni and industry experts [N15]. Finale panels had 4-5 judges. Muk Rao of Wharton Research Data Services sat on every panel from 2020 to 2026. An Aberdeen/abrdn judge sat every year from 2022 to 2026, and in 2024-2026 that judge was a fixed-income or credit specialist [N3][N6][N10][N13][N16]; Rao's 2020-21 panels per KB 2.2.
- **Past semifinal (2025-26).** A 10-minute pitch to the client, up to 15 slides, every member speaking, a case study of "one stock or ETF", four written answers of "250 words or fewer", and "Do NOT introduce completely new material, or your team will be disqualified" [D1]. This year's FAQ says "a short presentation (via video conference …) … to a live panel of judges" [W3]; the format is UNVERIFIED.
- **Finale.** About 10 minutes of pitch and 5 minutes of questions; "evaluated not only on their content, but also their delivery" [N3][N6][N13].

4.3 What winners did

Every champion from 2021-22 to 2025-26 was a US team [W4]. No winning strategy is public: "We do not release final reports from previous winners" [D8]. What is public:

- 2023 champions: "less is more, and having an explainable strategy makes a lot more sense than going for so many different things at once" [N7].
- Staples (2nd, 2024): others chased "the most money"; their approach was "personal first" [O1].
- A 2022-23 finalist: the skill they learned most was "starting with the goal and creating a portfolio, going backwards" [O2].
- Amity (2nd, 2023): a goal-first Monte Carlo tied to one client question (FROM R3). Marista (2nd, 2026): 15 months of work, seven of them preparation before the eight-month competition [O4]. Westminster (finalist, 2026): split roles; the school reports judges praised its "capacity to adapt and pivot" (school claim) [O5].
- Contrast: Hotchkiss built a nine-stage quant pipeline and stopped at the Top 50 (FROM R3).
- Clubs that keep learning across years keep coming back: TJHSST (finalist, 1st, 3rd, finalist) and Bergen County Academies (2nd, then 1st) (KB 5.1, P4).

4.4 What judges value and dislike (KB section 4)

Value	Dislike
"less is more … Cut slides, cut words, cut minutes" [N3]	"hiding behind fancy terms and formulas" [N12]
"simple, elegant ideas" [N12]	"Excessive investing jargon doesn't necessarily dazzle the judges" [D5]
"depth and accuracy" [N10]	Tools as strategy: Porter's Five Forces "on their own … are not a team strategy" [D4]
"clear thoughtfulness and reasoning behind all the decisions" (Aberdeen judge, 2025) [N13]	"authentic team voice, not generated or generic responses" (2025-26 semifinal) [D1]
"the ability to connect the client's objectives to an investment strategy" [N9]	Chasing returns: "Your WInS standings have no impact" [X1]
"take a look at this person holistically" [N10]	A strategy "buried somewhere in your experience" [W6]
"Your strategy is a set of rules and guidelines; a plan of attack" [D4]	Long, meandering explanations [D4]

4.5 What changed this year

Change	Evidence	Why it matters (INFERENCE)
Three graded deliverables read together; Strategy scores "consistency with the team's IPS"	deliverables.txt:27, :55; case:161	A number that differs between documents is visible to the same reader
The TNA is now separate and early; notes are checked against WInS	TNA brief:53	Notes written at trade time are primary evidence
The IPS freezes the strategy and trading on 6 Nov	IPS brief:72-74; Guide:122-127	Every Final Report calculation needs a principle already in the IPS
Portfolio Analysis now scores assumptions and projections "under varying market outcomes"	deliverables.txt:57 vs [D5]	Stated assumptions and good/bad cases earn marks; stock-picking tools earn less
Co-sponsor communication of uncertainty is inside Creativity	deliverables.txt:59	Credibility, not flair (case:114-116)
No sector minimum; no approved list; permitted list applies to the IPS and Final Report	[S2]; trading.txt:48	Each holding must be WInS-listed and fit for its purpose
Final Report instructions come later (9 Nov)	deliverables.txt:51	25 days to write, against 46 last year [X1]

4.6 International teams

About 40-51% of each Top 50 comes from outside the US, but no non-US team has won since 2021 [W4]. No Australian team has made a Top 50 since Brisbane State High in 2021-22 [N1][O6]. Persistence is the strongest pattern in the data (KB 5.1-5.2).

4.7 FORECAST: Final Report, semifinal, finale

Element	Likelihood	Evidence
TNR 12, double-spaced, 1-inch margins, PDF of 5 MB or less, no external links	Very high	[D6]; IPS brief:110-123
A page range, with "will not be reviewed" or disqualification outside it at both ends	High that a range exists; the numbers are UNVERIFIED	9-12 pages (2022-23); 10-13 plus Works Cited, with a report-details section of 5-8 pages (2023-24) [D6]
Portfolio-at-a-Glance: a WInS snapshot plus a recommended-portfolio snapshot	High	[D6]; [X2]
"Why are your WInS and recommended portfolios the same or different?" in about 150 words	Medium	[D6]
Team reflection (about 150 words); advisor reflection written by the advisor	Medium	[D6]; 2025 doc:84-86, :247
Works Cited (APA) including "1-2 sentences on how you used that AI tool"	High	[D6]; [W5]
Report addressed to the portfolio manager (teacher/advisor)	Medium-high	[D6]; case:4
The case analytics (reserve, certainty, contribution, 2031 range and confidence, part of the fundraising materials, projections, good and bad outcomes)	Very high	case:94-124, 146-149
Cash allowed in the recommended plan	UNVERIFIED	2025-26 list said "Aside from cash" [X1]; the 2026-27 list omits cash

Element	Likelihood	Evidence
Semifinal: about 10 minutes; every member speaks; ETF or stock case study; no new material	High (format UNVERIFIED)	[D1][W3]
Finale: 29-30 Apr 2027; in person or virtual; no travel funding; a fixed-income judge likely	Medium	[W1][W2][N16]

Part 5. Scorecard (AI opinion, no data)

Wharton publishes no scores, and simulated AI panels have scored the same IPS differently on different days (JUDGE-01 verifier note). So this table gives no numbers and no rank. Use it to see where student work is missing, never as a target.

Criterion	Where Caplet stands (AI opinion)	What raises it
Investment Strategy	Strong core idea. But "appropriate diversification" is barely argued, and the consistency between WInS and the IPS is not yet checked.	Items 4, 11, 12; the diversification principle (Part 3).
Client Knowledge	V5 drops flexibility, "responsible", liquidity and the residency itself. The risk paragraph rests on an inference.	Part 6 checklist; item 12.
Portfolio Analysis	All numbers are AI-built. There are two ladder bases. No student-owned projections exist. The certainty standard is undefined.	Items 4, 11, 18; each student rebuilds one number (item 22).
Articulation	Weakest. The journal is thin and stops on 7 Oct; key calls were deferred to AI; roles are blank.	Items 3, 17, 22.
Creativity and Presentation	The team's own note says V5 is AI-generated. The co-sponsor section has not started. The memorable lines are the wrong ones (Part 14).	Items 1, 12, 20.

The weakest criterion decides, because Wharton wants teams that score "exceptionally well on all five" (`faqs.txt:79`). So far, most of the AI research has gone into Strategy and Portfolio Analysis, and almost nothing student-made exists yet for Articulation (PM-01).

Part 6. Client knowledge

Problems found (`oct16/lenses/L02_client_forensic.findings.json`):

- **V5 drops the case's key ideas.**
  - "Flexib-", "responsib-" and "liquid-" appear 5, 4 and 1 times in the case, 6, 3 and 4 times in the IPS brief, and 0 times in V5.
  - V3 had a labelled certainty definition and "a responsible facility contribution that leaves Laura flexibility"; V5 lost both (CLIENT-01).
  - "Community" appears 0 times. The residency, where people "temporarily live, work, teach, and collaborate" (case:77-80), is never described (CLIENT-16).
- **The case's reserve and certainty asks have six parts:** the reserve's size; its initial composition; how it changes "if at all"; what "high degree of funding certainty" means; how it was evaluated; and the assumptions (case:96-99). There are also five assumption categories (case:146-148). V5 answers about one and a half (CLIENT-03).
- **Laura's kept half does three jobs:** payment backstop (V5:26), defence against inflation and the Taiwan dollar (V5:28), and cushion for costs and co-sponsor gaps (V5:30).
  - By 2033 it is about $28k in the middle case and $0 in a 1-in-20 case (MODEL, `results.json` laura_kept_2033).
  - Other files invest it in three different ways (CLIENT-02).
  - The case says no contingency fund needs sizing (case:106-107). Answer with a principle, not a sized cushion (CLIENT-V4).
- **"Responsible" has no test.** In the model's middle case Laura gives about 86% of her unreserved money (a ratio of two medians, MODEL; JUDGE-12). The case warns that "committing all remaining assets could limit her financial flexibility" (case:101-103).
- **The shortfall chain must end inside the portfolio.** A rab memo says "she adds her own money" (`rab/decisions/D6_cap_share.md:54`), but the case forbids relying on outside funding (case:91-92). V5's "stays with Laura" reads as money leaving the portfolio (CLIENT-13).
- **The risk paragraph infers risk appetite from her statistics degree** and says "the artists would bear the loss". The case makes neither link. Its own words are "willing to take thoughtful risks" and "an appropriate balance" (case:68-74; CLIENT-07, IPS-15).
- **Holding about 7% in stocks is never explained in client terms,** for a client with an "entrepreneurial mindset" (case:40-41; CLIENT-06).
- **"Meaningful" is half of the co-sponsor test** (case:110-112). Caplet argues only "credible" (CLIENT-11).
- **The fixed $50k loses buying power.** At 2.5% inflation the 2042 payment is worth about $40k in 2033 dollars (CLIENT-09). The case asks for "the effect of inflation on portfolio projections and facility costs" (case:147).
- **Currency.** The case says "dollar range" and never names a currency. If any co-sponsor counts in NT$, a typical two-year currency move (one standard deviation) is about 6.6% (MODEL; CLIENT-10, G1-04). One labelled assumption is enough; say who bears currency moves.
- **The case's role-play** says the advisor "makes the final investment decisions" (case:4). The real rules say "Advisors may not make decisions on behalf of students" (Rules & Roles). Describe the real process (CLIENT-21).
- **Language about Laura in team notes** ("her quote", "not a typical artist", identity labels) must not reach a deliverable (CLIENT-15).

Co-sponsor evidence: the net position.

- The team calls this its "most original part", but the key source is misread (L04-V1; https://kresge.org/sites/default/files/GuidetoChallengeGrant.pdf, accessed 16 Oct 2026):
  - the Kresge guide counts more than "written pledges or cash": it also lists organisational funds, long-term financing and in-kind gifts;
  - its question 6 is about keeping donor support, not about running costs;
  - it is dated "Updated June 30, 2011", and Kresge says the challenge grant is "no longer the centerpiece of our work".
- The one Taiwan funder source found is the Ministry of Culture's artist-village grant. It funds yearly operating plans and upgrades to equipment and facilities, not new construction, and it runs one year at a time, subject to the budget vote (https://www.hccc.gov.tw/Utility/DisplayFile?id=7839, 2019 text, accessed 16 Oct 2026; G1-02, G1-03). So V5's pitch premise ("co-sponsors who fund the building rarely pay to run it", V5:16) is at risk.
- Usable, with limits, mostly from US studies (UNIQ-05): numbers placed next to probability words; keeping a promise beats exceeding it; announcing a lead gift raises giving. The "17 languages" study names China and Hong Kong, not Taiwan (G1-06).

Co-sponsor excerpt checklist (facts only; students write the text):

- The range in US dollars, with its date and basis.
- A bought bottom, and a top set by a stated rule.
- One confidence figure with its method, kept separate from payment certainty.
- Where in the range the gift is likely to land (the sheet says at or within $1,000 of the top in about 3 in 4 paths, MODEL).
- What bad markets do, and who bears currency moves.
- A re-quote rule for the 2031-33 campaign.
- One set of numbers for every co-sponsor (Taiwan public grants require declared budget lines to match, G1-05).
- No promise to exceed the top. No invented quote. No claim that Laura will get any grant.
- Whether to offer matching is a team choice (the "don't match" research is UNVERIFIED).

Done when: the client lead turns the case into a one-page checklist and ticks every draft against it (CLIENT-18).

Part 7. Strategy red team

What holds. Buying the ten payments early with Treasuries held to maturity fits a fixed, nominal promise that only the portfolio can fund (case:90-92). Wharton's "funding purposes" wording supports holding one issuer on purpose for that money (trading.txt:49).

What a bond judge will break (`oct16/lenses/L03_strategy_redteam.findings.json`):

1. **"Depends mainly on the US government" ignores coupons.** That is true for the principal, not for the coupons. The WInS holdings rely on reinvested income for about $45k of the $500k (STRAT-02). The sheet shows about $21k short if yields fall 2 points for good, and a 1-in-20 shortfall of about $25k (MODEL, `IPS_number_sheet.md:30-45`). The team's own notes already say "reinvested coupons fund the rest" (05:18), and the IBTM note says "the final payout is not fixed" (05:19).
2. **Most of that risk arrives after the 2033 gift is paid.** About 72% of the reinvestment dependence is earned after 1 Jan 2033 (MODEL, STRAT-03). V5's shortfall order covers only a shortfall "expected in 2033" (V5:26).
3. **Wrong-way risk.** The backstop (Laura's half of the stock fund) is smallest exactly when yields and stocks fall together. In the kit's own 2008 replay, Laura keeps $18,446 and the gap beyond her half is $12,047 (`rab/decisions/D_stress_bad_year.md:32`; VER-L03-03). Both models assume rates and stocks move independently.
4. **The trade-off sentence runs the wrong way.** V5:28 and COMPETITION.md:164 say less stock lowers the expected contribution. Under the plan's own cap rule, a smaller floor lowers the median gift; only total wealth rises (STRAT-06, IPS-18).
5. **There are two readings of the floor:** "the remainder" (V5:24) or "about $150k" (COMPETITION.md:155-156). Either way, low yields hit the facility twice. On the 2 Jan 2026 curve the ladder alone would have cost about $317-325k (STRAT-08).
6. **iBond mechanics are glossed over** (STRAT-09):
   - the funds sit in cash in their final months;
   - the 0.07% fee adds up over the life to roughly today's whole room;
   - about 61% of the WInS book is with one fund sponsor;
   - V5's "substitute a Treasury maturing earlier" runs into WInS's gap: no Treasury maturing Feb 2031 to Feb 2036.
7. **The reserve's size and composition over time are not stated.** Its market value on 1 Jan 2033 depends on 2033 yields: about $376k at 7%, $405k at 5%, $439k at 3% (MODEL; STRAT-11).

Fix options for item 11 (cost, and what each covers).

- **State the risk:** no cost; the payments stay at about 93 in 100 (MODEL). The wording must not put "secure" next to a failure rate (COMM-09).
- **Keep Laura's half in the portfolio to 2042:** no cost now, but it still depends on stocks (wrong-way risk).
- **A buffer from the 2028 deposit:** about $10-20k, which lowers the floor by the same amount; "A $20k buffer covers a 2-point fall" (`IPS_number_sheet.md:53-54`).
- **A dedicated (cash-flow-matched) build from the same kind of holdings:** about $309.6k if waiting cash earns 0%, or $304.1k at 2%, on the 15 Oct curve. That is about $4-10k above $300k (MODEL, single build; STRAT-04). It drops the IBTM 2033 rung and the Feb-2037 bond, which filled TNA notes describe, so it must be presented as a refinement.

Whichever is chosen, check it against the notes, which cannot be edited, and prefer a cover that does not depend on stocks.

Hardest judge questions (each student should be able to answer two, from material they built):

- Why are the first five payments in funds whose payout is not fixed?
- Several bonds mature up to 10.5 months early. Where does that money wait, and at what rate?
- What happens to the payments if yields fall 2 points and stay there? Who pays?
- Why is your promise to co-sponsors safer than your promise to the artists?
- About 92% of Laura's 2028 plan is in one issuer (about 90% of the WInS book): why is that "appropriate diversification"?
- About 7% in stocks for a client "willing to take thoughtful risks": why so little?
- Why not corporate bonds? There is a dated answer. Swapping IBTM-IBTR for same-year corporate iBonds frees about $10.7k before credit losses, and about $4-9k after allowing for them (MODEL, 14-15 Oct data; G2-01). Individual corporate bonds are not permitted, and no dated corporate fund reaches 2038-2042 (G2-02).
- "No dollar asset is safer"? The US is no longer rated AAA (iShares shows IBTM as "AA Rated 99.97%"; check each agency's current rating on the day before quoting, as Appendix C says). Use market pricing instead: on 14 Oct, AAA-rated corporate bonds paid 0.40% more than Treasuries (FRED, accessed 16 Oct 2026; G2-03).
- Why not TIPS (inflation-linked Treasuries)? The payments are fixed in dollars (case:90). The kit's "1.43 times the size" figure is on the STRIPS basis; re-run it before quoting (STRAT-14).
- Why not other governments' bonds? Whether the rules allow them is unresolved (`COMPETITION.md:77`). Currency risk is about $10-12k per payment over 10 years, and no hedge is allowed (G2-05).

Part 8. Trades and the TNA

Facts.

- All 11 orders were placed within about 24.5 hours (6 Oct 7:55 PM to 7 Oct 8:27 PM ET) and filled on 7-8 Oct (TNA-04).
- Four notes sit on cancelled orders. The cancelled IBTR note said "0.3" percentage points; the filled one says "0.2" (`05_trading_note_reflection_wins_trading_notes.md:33-40`).
- Wharton does not score the number of trades (Guide:74-77) and advises against frequent trading (`faqs.txt:39`).
- Word overlap of the filled notes with AI example notes: Nov-2040 45%, Nov-2039 36%, IBTM 31%, VT 28%, IBTR 2%. No note is a copy of an AI note. Nobody has recorded who wrote or typed each note (INT-09). Each student privately records this by Thu 22 Oct. If IBTM or VT is picked, the Works Cited names the AI example notes behind it.

What each reflection must prove (students write; 100 words or fewer; JUDGE-16, TNA-06/07/08, COMM-14):

- **IBTR (a rule set in advance).**
  - Show the pre-set test and what the team did as it nearly fired.
  - Any figure is dated and on the note's own basis (holdings, yields unchanged): about 23bp on 6 Oct, 4.7bp on 15 Oct (Box A).
  - Say the cost to Laura: less money for the facility.
  - Give the scale once if a dollar amount appears.
  - Give the reason for locking in early: the payments are fixed in dollars, and waiting leaves them exposed to falling yields. Wharton's only example note models a gradual shift instead (TNA instructions :36-39).
  - Do not say "locked" or "secured": "enough for all ten payments" depends on reinvesting coupons (TNA-V02).
- **IBTM (a change forced by the 6 Oct email).**
  - Say what the email changed: STRIPS are out, and IBTM becomes the real floor.
  - Liquidity: the fund ends about 15 Dec 2032, 17 days before the first payment.
  - Use no certainty word stronger than the note's own "payout is not fixed".
- **VT (a choice among alternatives).**
  - Name the alternatives weighed. A teammate's 5 Oct challenge ("copout"; stock picking, EWT, GLD) still reads "Outcome and reasons: [fill in]" (`final_report.md:23`). Record the outcome first.
  - State the trade-off and the size: about 7% of Laura's plan (MODEL), 8.8% of the WInS book at cost.
  - Deal honestly with the note's "only" and "promised", which sit uneasily with V5's three jobs for Laura's half (COH-03, TNA-14).
  - Use Wharton's "funding purposes" frame for diversification.
- **Together:** three different kinds of decision; each reflection links once to the other two; together they cover growth, risk, liquidity, funding reliability and flexibility. Do not define Laura's kept half as "flexibility" if vote set B may make it the payment back-up (CLIENT-17).

Optional polish. If the form allows, add one identifier line per pick outside the 100 words: security, buy, quantity, and order date and time as WInS shows them (TNA-12).

Part 9. The IPS

The brief, in one line. The IPS should "establish your strategic approach to preparing for the operating commitment, managing the operating reserve's asset composition over time, determining a responsible facility contribution, and preserving appropriate financial flexibility" (IPS instructions :48-50). It is "not expected to include final operating-reserve calculations, detailed portfolio projections, a final facility-contribution range" (:68-70).

IPS checklist (what a student draft must achieve).

- **The central idea up front:** in the pitch and the first two sentences of the body. Seven drafts open by restating the case ("This policy governs ..."), and the strategy's name appears only at word 167 (COMM-17, IPS-08). Wharton's 2022-24 judging page: "Don't use precious space repeating known facts about your client" (https://globalyouth.wharton.upenn.edu/wp-json/wp/v2/pages/3778, accessed 16 Oct 2026).
- **A pitch built on Laura's goal** and the rule that only the portfolio can fund the payments (case:91-92), not on a claim about how co-sponsors behave. No dollar figure. 45 words or fewer.
- **Each required theme handled as a principle, in the case's words** (IPS :45-50; JUDGE-06, IPS-07):
  - risk and return (a return objective in words);
  - liquidity (cash each 1 Jan, and a named WInS-listed home for waiting money);
  - portfolio construction and diversification;
  - how the mix changes over time;
  - the operating commitment;
  - the reserve's composition over time;
  - a responsible contribution;
  - flexibility.
- **One certainty standard**, true for the bonds Caplet owns. It names the remaining risks (default, iBond payout, coupon reinvestment, waiting cash, yields before Jan 2027, the 2028 deposit) and says which money absorbs each (IPS-03).
- **No absolute word that the team's own numbers contradict:** not "never below the floor", "cannot miss the range" or "no dollar asset is safer" (IPS-04, COMM-01). The journal says "never below the floor" was kept on purpose because the real floor was to be STRIPS (`final_report.md:24`); that reason ended on 6 Oct.
- **The rules from item 11, in time order** (2027, 2028, yearly review, 2031, 2033, 2033-42), each with its trigger. The monitoring rule needs measures, and must cover the two likeliest events: the ladder costing more than $300k, and a late or small 2028 deposit (IPS-20, UNIQ-11).
- **The legal constraint in one line:** only WInS-listed stocks, ETFs and Treasury bonds (live FAQ; Part 2, item 4).
- **One name per idea.** Today the stock fund has five names and the floor four (JUDGE-15, IPS-17).
- **No named sources, tickers or coupons** (the citation ban; and the brief's "rather than describing individual investments", :51-52).
- **A word budget per section,** with a total of 470 or less on the stricter counter. Every addition names what it cuts.

The 13 [AI] suggestions (`caplet-latest/research/ips_numbers_2026-10/IPS_v5_suggestions.md`).

No.	Problem	Default
2	Changes "mainly" to "only" for principal. That is false for the five iBond rungs, whose notes say the payout "is not fixed"	Reject
5	"about $294,000": payment-date basis, unlabelled. The pitch keeps "$292,000", so the IPS would disagree with itself	Reject as written
6	"normally $150,000", while the floor is below $150k in about 1 path in 3 (MODEL)	Reject as written
7 + 8	Together they delete V5's only diversification content ("thousands of companies" and the one-issuer sentence)	Reject unless the content survives elsewhere
9	Cuts the review trigger and substitution rule, one of the few decision rules	Reject
10	Adds "$21,000 short" without saying who covers it	Only after item 11 decides the cover
11-12	Put a dollar range and "99 times in 100" into the frozen IPS. The brief does not expect them, and they will differ by 4 Dec	Reject by default
13	Drops the cost-overrun job without fixing the kept half's job list	Only after item 11

Taken together, the suggestions keep the length the same but double the dollar figures (5 to 10) and mix four formats for odds (COMM-08). If any item is used, take the fact, not the sentence, and log it.

Part 10. Final Report and finale readiness

Why it is the biggest risk. The Final Report carries Portfolio Analysis, most of Articulation and the co-sponsor part of Creativity almost on its own (FR-08). It is half of the Top 50 basis, it has the shortest window, and it is due after Knox's term ends (FR-01).

What must exist before 9 Nov (item 18, plus):

- **A decision on what "recommended portfolio" means** (FORECAST: Jan 2028). Build each snapshot as a team table (holding, job, payment year, value, weight) from WInS numbers. WInS labels the iBond funds "Long Equities" (61.6%, `COMPETITION.md:98`), so add a line explaining the label (FR-03).
- **A plan-vs-actual scorecard for each order:** target vs actual weight, fill, time, commission, what went wrong, and the rule it produced (FR-05).
- **A weekly record from 7 Nov to 4 Dec:** WInS value, cash, income, the ladder's value against the value of the payments it covers, VT, and the 10-year yield (FR-06).
- **No new material later.** Anything the semifinal might show must already be in the report (FR-17).
- **WInS-listed securities only.** Every security in any recommended portfolio must be WInS-listed. In 2023-24, "Teams that include prohibited securities in their final report are not eligible for the Semifinals" (page 3778, accessed 16 Oct 2026; VER-L07-01).

Hard Q&A list. Use the questions in Part 7, plus "What was your job, and what value did you add?" and "Which decision did you argue against, and what happened?" (TP-03).

More from the Final Report review

- **Fixed by official text.** The five criteria apply. Instructions arrive Mon 9 Nov ET, and the report is due Fri 4 Dec 5 pm ET. The report must evaluate how well the IPS strategy was implemented (IPS brief:75-77). Teams "may identify decisions you would make differently, but you may not redesign your strategy after observing the results" (Guide:158-159). Sources for IPS claims belong in the Final Report (IPS brief:124-125). The case analytics are required (case:94-124, 130-133, 146-149): reserve size, mix and changes; the certainty definition, its evaluation and assumptions; the contribution and its justification; the 2031 range with confidence and good/bad market effects; part of the fundraising materials; projections from $300k plus $150k with stated return, inflation and risk assumptions under favourable and unfavourable outcomes.
- **Portfolio-at-a-Glance trap (FR-03).** Caplet's plan has three dates: Jan 2027 ($300k), Jan 2028 ($450k) and the 2033 reserve that shrinks each year. Say which date the "recommended portfolio" shows. The WInS book is the Jan 2028 plan scaled to $300k (portfolio.csv:2), a factor of about 0.643 ($300k / about $467k; L08), with IBTM split into 1,142 payment shares and 3,361 floor shares (:38-39). A past spec asked for sector percentages in each snapshot.
- **IPS hooks the Final Report needs** (L07 section 3.2). Reserve path: partial (V5:26). Certainty definition and test: missing (V5:20). Contribution rule: present (V5:30). 2031 method: present, but no valuation date. Shortfall order: present, but only for 2033. Return assumption: missing. Inflation and FX: named, not quantified. Flexibility kept: present (V5:30). Each missing hook must become a principle in the IPS by 6 Nov, or the Final Report cannot use it (FR-09, VER-L07-02).
- **Collect now** (L07 section 6): a decision log; an evidence file per decision; meeting notes; roles with one product each; a challenges log; a weekly learning line from each student; the AI-use record; an APA source list with access dates; WInS captures; the Trade Log; trigger checks and decisions not to trade; weekly tracking after the freeze; a data pack for the valuation date (6 Nov close); chart data; the co-sponsor facts checklist; the school letter; an advisor heads-up; an availability calendar for 10 Nov-4 Dec and late Jan-Apr 2027.
- **Five charts, each answering one client question (FR-13):** a cash-flow timeline 2027-2042; the 2031 range; coupon-reinvestment sensitivity; ladder value vs the payments it covers during WInS; allocation over time. Students build them from data they can explain. None go in the IPS, and none is a WInS pie chart.
- **"What we would do differently" (FR-16).** Agree a two-column list before drafting: implementation lessons (order timing, after-hours iBond spreads, AI in WInS, roles set late, decisions not logged) vs strategy questions. State strategy weaknesses as limitations with their size, never as changes.

- **Semifinal and finale (FORECAST).** Last year's video was due 13 days after the 27 Jan announcement (Mon 9 Feb, 8:00 am ET) [D1]. That window ran from the last days of the Australian summer holidays into the first two weeks of Knox Term 1 (Term 1 2027 starts Fri 29 Jan [K1]). An 8:00 am ET deadline in February is midnight in Sydney (TP-03). The finale (29-30 Apr 2027, week 1 of Knox Term 2 [K1]) is covered in item 25; also note that an adult must accompany an in-person team [W2] (FR-19).

More hard questions (client, process, AI) beyond Part 7; each answer must be the student's own:

1. In one sentence, what is your strategy and why does Laura need it?
2. Why lock almost all of the first $300k now instead of shifting into bonds over time?
3. What does "high degree of certainty" mean to you, in numbers, and how did you test it?
4. Why iBond funds for 2033-37 and not individual Treasuries? (WInS lists none maturing between 15 Feb 2031 and 15 Feb 2036.)
5. Why give half the fund to the facility? Why not 80/20?
6. How big is the operating reserve in 2033, and what does it hold each year?
7. Markets crash in 2032 after she has quoted the range. What does she tell co-sponsors?
8. A fixed $50,000 loses buying power. How does the plan handle inflation and the Taiwan dollar?
9. Your WInS book is $300k and her plan is $450k. How does one represent the other, and why does WInS call your bond funds "Long Equities"?
10. Walk us through one trade note: what did you know then, and what changed?
11. Why not rebalance when markets move?
12. Why VT and not the S&P 500, Taiwan stocks or gold?
13. Tell us about a mistake. What happened on 7 Oct? (Truthfully, including the AI click and the rule it produced.)
14. How did you use AI, and how do we know this work is yours? (A student re-derives a number live.)
15. Who made the decisions? What did your advisor do?
16. What did each of you contribute? (Honestly; no ranking.)
17. What would you do differently, without changing the strategy?
18. Why should Laura choose your plan over a team that promises a bigger gift?

Part 11. Integrity and compliance

Rule (exact text)	Evidence in Caplet's files	Fix
"AI-generated work may not be submitted as your own." (Rules & Roles); students "must use their voice and words" (AI policy page)	V5 "Best version that AI generated" (V5:36); 13 AI rewrites; the 16 Oct rule (`caplet-latest/CLAUDE.md:27-30`)	Items 1 and 12. No AI wording in the TNA reflections, Articulation or co-sponsor text. The AI policy page's guidance says: "Don't use AI for personal reflection or opinion-based tasks"
"If you use AI to assist you in any way during the competition, how you use it must be recorded in your Works Cited pages." (AI policy page)	The new rule credits only "accepted AI wording" (INT-V01); the log has a gap for 1-15 Oct (INT-10)	The Works Cited records all AI use: ideas, models, numbers, charts, example notes, suggestions accepted or rejected, reviews, browser use
Plagiarism is "the use of another's words or ideas as if they are one's own" (Rules & Roles)	The core idea came from the AI council (`notes_and_discussions.md:69`); "the team deferred" (CLAUDE.md:75)	Credit AI for the idea; log the students' own votes, reasons and dissent (INT-04, TP-01)
"We trust that you will not … invent teamwork and experiential stories" (Rules & Roles)	Journal blanks; last year's "make up stories" comment	Item 17
"Teams are not permitted to contact Laura Gao." (`client.txt:23`)	COMPETITION.md:49 says "fictional"	Item 6
Students place trades (`faqs.txt:34`); Stock-Trak's terms ban robots and retrieval devices (whether they bind the Wharton edition is UNVERIFIED)	The 7 Oct AI browser click; "AI may fill a ticket up to Preview"; routines that may read logged-in WInS and SMApply (INT-08)	No AI in WInS or SMApply at all, not even read-only
Title-page names "should be the same as what was submitted with your official roster" (IPS :94)	No roster record in the repo (`config/team_roster.json` says PENDING)	Item 14
"Teams suspected … of using paid advisors, education consultants … or other agents will be disqualified." (Rules & Roles)	Routines say "You are the consultant for Team Caplet" (`ops/routines/MONITOR.md:3`)	Rename the routine role (low risk, cheap fix; INT-07)
Recording or "posting presentations or participants online during the Semifinals or Global Finale is strictly prohibited" (Rules & Roles)	Public repo and fork	Keep drafts, title pages, the school letter and any semifinal material on the private Drive only (FR-18)

Two more.

- [AI] suggestions placed in the live Google Doc appear under a student's account, and they lose the [AI] tag once accepted. That weakens the Doc history as proof of authorship (INT-V02). Keep AI findings in separate files, and have students type any change themselves.
- The public repo describes AI-detector testing of the IPS exemplars (`docs/AI_USE.md:65-66`). Do not delete it (git keeps it anyway); describe the exemplars honestly in the Works Cited (INT-06).

Part 12. Coherence and numbers: contradictions and which is right

#	Says	Elsewhere says	Which is right
1	Feb-2037 bond 5.000% (`COMPETITION.md:181`)	4.750% (WInS ID at 05:16; `portfolio.csv:25`)	4.750%
2	"Laura is a fictional client" (`COMPETITION.md:49`)	"While the client is real" (main page); contact banned (`client.txt:23`)	Real (the main page adds that "the financial scenario is developed specifically for the competition")
3	"Roots First" (`COMPETITION.md:147`, :204)	"Root-and-Branch" (V5:24; `final_report.md:21`)	Team vote; the journal says Root-and-Branch was settled
4	"The team writes all deliverables" (`caplet-latest/START_HERE.md:26`)	AI may suggest wording (`caplet-latest/CLAUDE.md:27-30`; `caplet-latest/COMPETITION.md:142-143`); main CLAUDE.md still has the old rule (`CLAUDE.md:23`)	Item 1 vote
5	Students "wrote all submitted text" (`caplet-latest/docs/AI_USE.md:91`)	AI memos, AI example notes, AI-generated V5	False template; item 16
6	"$293k on the 6 Oct curve" (`COMPETITION.md:153-154`, holdings basis)	"about $294,000" on 15 Oct (`IPS_number_sheet.md:12`, payment-date basis)	Different bases. Like for like, the cost rose by about $5.2k (holdings) or about $5.5k (payment dates) since 6 Oct (VER-L08-01)
7	"$7.7k = 27bp" marked VERIFIED (CLAUDE.md:121-122)	"$5,613 (19bp), not $7.7k/27bp" (CLAUDE.md:106-107)	Both superseded; use Box A
8	Six floor definitions (COH-04)	-	Item 11 vote. One candidate is the sheet's "$150,000 face, quoted as $145,000", lowered by any ladder top-up (`IPS_number_sheet.md:14`)

#	Says	Elsewhere says	Which is right
9	Stocks "~9%" / "~$40k" (`COMPETITION.md:156`; CLAUDE.md:92, :96)	About 7% / $32k (sheet, with the leftover kept in Treasuries); 8.8% VT in WInS at cost	Plan figure: about 7% (16 Oct sheet, MODEL). Give the WInS figure separately
10	VT note: stocks "only" set the gift (05:14)	Laura's half has three more jobs (V5:26, :28, :30)	Item 11 decides; the VT reflection deals with it
11	Less stock means a lower median contribution (V5:28; `COMPETITION.md:164`)	A smaller floor lowers the median gift (STRAT-06)	The sentence is wrong for the gift
12	"depends mainly on the US government" (V5:20)	"reinvested coupons fund the rest" (05:18); "payout is not fixed" (05:19)	The notes
13	"income reinvested in the holding that paid it" (V5:26)	"a short-term Treasury ETF" (05:16-17); WInS cash earns 0%	One income rule that matches the notes
14	Shortfall order: leftover, then half, then gift (V5:26); the bottom is lowered (V5:30)	"Name her half as the first cover" (D6:79); the top is lowered (D_range:44-47)	Item 11
15	"she adds her own money" (D6:54)	No outside money (case:91-92)	The case
16	Top 50 "chosen on the written Trading Notes, IPS and Final Report" (CLAUDE.md:26)	"based on ... IPS and Final Reports" (Rules & Roles)	Quote the Rules page; all three are evaluated
17	"short video presentation" (`COMPETITION.md:26`)	"via video conference ... to a live panel" (`faqs.txt:89`)	The FAQ
18	"about 91% Treasuries" (`COMPETITION.md:98`)	89.5-90.2% (`rab/trades/tickets.md:124`)	Cash excluded vs included; state the basis
19	"Show chart 02" (`deliverables/ips_outline.md:19`)	Charts banned (IPS :123)	The IPS rules
20	"$500,000 virtual portfolio" (`team/google_drive/team_list.md:69`)	$300,000 (`trading.txt:26`)	$300,000; tell the advisor
21	Sheet header: built on "WInS-listed holdings" (`IPS_number_sheet.md:5`)	The cost is priced to payment dates (`ips_numbers.py:87`)	Label it as the payment-date basis
22	"494 after all twelve" (`IPS_v5_suggestions.md:5`)	13 rows; 498 words after all 13, counted by spaces (COMM-08)	13 rows, 498 words

One numbers sheet, owned by the rates analyst, gives each figure's date, basis and type (market price, model, or assumption). The IPS and Final Report use the 6 Nov close; the TNA uses the writer's dated run (COH-19).

Part 13. Team and process

Roles (suggested; the team assigns names in its own private sheet; at most three roles per person, each with a backup; TP-05):

- lead;
- deputy;
- trader (Ray, by team rule) and a checker who reads every ticket back;
- historian and AI-log keeper;
- rates analyst (owns the numbers sheet);
- growth/risk analyst;
- client/co-sponsor lead;
- rules, format and privacy lead;
- editor.

Each student also owns one TNA reflection or IPS section, one Final Report section and one 60-second topic.

Why it matters.

- Key strategy calls began as AI council output, and no record shows the students' own reasons or the options they rejected (TP-01). A 1 Oct team decision is recorded ("IPS content locked", `final_report.md:21`; the tickets sheet had planned "the team's 1 Oct vote", `rb_tickets.csv:1`), but nobody recorded who argued what.
- One person is a single point of failure. Every commit on main is by one student or by the AI; no other student has committed (git log of main, 16 Oct; TP-04).
- The failure the 28 Sep pre-mortem imagined has largely come true (`research/insight_v1/phase_E/E5_premortem.md:271-273`; TP-05).
- The rule files disagree (TP-09). Information reaches one person, and the other five see 14 Oct snapshots (TP-12).
- The written "lessons from last year" leave out every process lesson, and several are repeating: one person at the centre of all work, AI-iterated drafts, AI judging, empty logs (TP-14).

A team charter (one page, agreed Sun 18 Oct or Tue 27 Oct; TP-08):

- Strategy, trades, the AI rule, anything submitted and the strategy's name need a logged whole-team vote.
- The section owner decides wording inside their own section.
- The AI memory file records only team decisions, each with its date and vote.

Operating rhythm to 4 Dec.

When (Sydney)	What
Every Sunday	30-minute meeting with five decisions at most; a 15-minute review of open items; a five-line digest in the team chat (what changed, what was decided, what is due, who owns it, any Wharton email in full)
Sat 17 Oct	Items 6, 7
Sun 18 Oct	Items 1-5
Mon 19 - Thu 22 Oct	Items 8-10 and 10b; an outside reader scores the TNA on Wed 21 Oct (scores only)
Sun 25 Oct	10-minute retrospective; journal and AI-log back-fill (items 16, 17); log the outcome of the 5 Oct challenge
Tue 27 Oct	Vote set B (item 11)
Wed 28 Oct - Thu 5 Nov	IPS: outline Wed 28, draft Sat 31, format check Wed 4, submit Thu 5 Nov
Sat 7 - Mon 9 Nov	WInS capture; numbers rebuilt on the 6 Nov close; first no-laptop test Sun 8 Nov
Tue 10 Nov	Read the Final Report instructions; replace every FORECAST
Sun 15, 22, 29 Nov	Source log and Taiwan reading (15th); co-sponsor excerpt (22nd); full draft and page check (29th)
Fri 20 Nov	School letter in hand
Wed 2 Dec	Submit the Final Report (term ends Thu 3 Dec)

AI input: at most one page per role per week, chosen by that student. The AI answers a named student's question with a number, a check or a list of problems, and sends nothing unasked (TP-11). No new waves of AI research until the TNA and IPS are in (PM-01).

HSC exams run from 13 Oct to 5 Nov (NESA, accessed 16 Oct 2026). Whether any member sits them is UNVERIFIED. Give no writing task to a student in their exam week. Every deadline is a Saturday morning in Sydney, so submit 36-48 hours early.

Part 14. Communication

The lines a judge will remember from V5 are the wrong ones: the unsupported co-sponsor claim, "never below the floor", "cannot miss the range" and "no dollar asset is safer" (COMM-01). The true, simple idea ("the bottom of the range is money she already owns rather than a forecast", `team/google_drive/strategy_notes.md:20`) is not in V5.

A four-line story test (structure, not text): client problem, idea, proof, trade-off. Each line must be literally true, use the case's words, contain no team-made term, and carry at most one dated number on the right basis. Today no line of V5 passes all four tests (COMM-03). The clearest trade-off sentence in the whole entry is already in the filled IBTR note: cause, rule, cost to Laura (05:15; COMM-14).

Jargon blacklist (`oct16/lenses/L11_communication.md` section 6). In the TNA, keep each filled note's own word (Part 2, item 3).

Avoid	Plain replacement
roots / branch	the payment bonds / the world stock fund
floor, facility floor (reads as the floor of a building)	minimum, with the case's words "facility contribution"
cap, capped	upper limit, top of the range
cushion, the half Laura keeps	the case's words "financial flexibility"
building	facility
high certainty	the case's words "high degree of funding certainty"
headroom	money to spare
rung	bond for one year
defined-maturity Treasury ETF, iBond	a Treasury fund that pays out in a set year (define once)
bp, basis points	percentage points
p5 / p50 / p95, paths	bad case / typical case / good case; simulated futures
reinvestment-rate risk	the risk that interest earned later is lower
secure, guaranteed, risk-free, never, cannot miss, promised	bought, owned, designed to, "in our model, in X of 100 cases"
rarely (about co-sponsor habits)	the case's word "may"

Judges know "Treasury", "yield", "ETF" and "ladder". Team-made words cost marks. Co-sponsor text uses everyday words only, tested on an adult with no finance background (COMM-11).

Number rules (L11 section 7):

- One claim, one figure, in all three documents.
- A date and a type on every market or model number; never a bare "today".
- In text, round dollars to the nearest $1,000 and ranges to the nearest $5,000.
- "Percentage points" for yield changes; never "bp".
- One format for odds: "X in 100", always with "in our model".
- Say whether a figure is for Laura's plan or for the WInS copy.
- Dates with month names; WInS events in ET.
- Australian spelling throughout ("defence", not "defense"; COMM-19).

Part 15. Pre-mortem: how this ends outside the Top 50

These are stories, not forecasts. The AI's earlier odds for them were guesses with no data, so they are dropped (`oct16/lenses/L12_premortem.findings.json`).

1. **The Final Report is written in the last few days** (PM-02). Guard: items 17, 18, 21.
2. **The voice reads as AI** (PM-03). Guard: items 1, 12.
3. **Competent but not memorable** (PM-07). Guard: Part 3, at most three ideas.
4. **The IPS freezes rules that protect the range better than the payments** (PM-04). Guard: item 11.
5. **The TNA and IPS disagree on numbers or words** (PM-05, PM-06). Guard: items 4, 8; Box A.
6. **A hard gate fails:** format, a note mismatch, the letter, or a submission button (PM-12). Guard: items 7, 10, 10b, 14.
7. **The key calls are not the students' own, and it shows under questions** (PM-09). Guard: items 3, 22.

Part 16. Stop doing

- Stop accepting AI sentences into anything that is submitted.
- Stop quoting a ladder figure without its date and basis, and stop quoting results.json's "ladder_headroom".
- Stop adding notes or trades in WInS for show.
- Stop running AI detectors or "humanising" passes on drafts.
- Stop starting new waves of AI research before the IPS is in.
- Stop letting rules change without a team vote.
- Stop copying from COMPETITION.md, the Strategy Brief PDF or rab memos without checking the date and basis.
- Stop using AI in WInS or SMApply, even read-only.
- Stop committing anything with names, the WInS username, title pages or the school letter.

Appendix A. Sources (web sources accessed 16 Oct 2026)

Wharton Global Youth (base https://globalyouth.wharton.upenn.edu)

- [W1] Investment Competition main page: /competitions/investment-competition/
- [W2] General Rules & Roles: /competitions/investment-competition/rules-roles/
- [W3] FAQ: /competitions/investment-competition/faq/
- [W4] Archive, previous winners: /competitions/investment-competition/archive/
- [W5] AI Policy: /ai-policy/

- [W6] Developing a Strategy (legacy guidebook): /developing-strategy/
- [N1] /news/introducing-the-2022-semifinalists-in-the-wharton-global-high-school-investment-competition/
- [N3] /news/top-teams-sail-to-success-in-the-2022-wharton-investment-competition-global-finale/
- [N6] /news/the-2023-investment-competition-global-finale-ends-in-sweet-victory-for-dmvs-finest/
- [N7] /news/wharton-investment-competition-tales-from-the-2023-teams/
- [N8] /news/here-are-the-top-50-teams-advancing-to-wharton-global-youths-2024-investment-competition-semifinals/
- [N9] /news/wharton-global-youth-hosts-five-virtual-events-to-announce-the-2024-investment-competition-finalists/
- [N10] /news/spark-investments-bergen-county-academies-new-jersey-bring-the-heat-to-the-2024-investment-competition-global-finale/
- [N11] /news/announcing-the-semifinalists-in-the-2025-wharton-global-high-school-investment-competition/
- [N12] /news/lets-go-announcing-the-top-10-teams-advancing-to-the-wharton-investment-competitions-2025-global-finale/
- [N13] /news/bam-investing-from-deerfield-academy-massachusetts-wins-the-2025-wharton-global-high-school-investment-competition/
- [N14] /news/a-winning-season-thousands-of-teams-bigger-stakes-and-the-top-50-2026-investment-competition-teams-revealed/
- [N15] /news/11-teams-advance-to-the-2026-wharton-global-high-school-investment-competition-global-finale/
- [N16] /articles/2026-investment-competition-global-champions/ (redirects to /news/2026-investment-competition-global-champions/)
- [N22] /investment-competition/previous-winners/case-study-for-2021-2022/
- [D1] /wp-content/uploads/2026/01/25%E2%80%9326-Semifinalists-%E2%80%93-Next-Steps-FINAL.pdf
- [D4] /wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Technical-Feedback-23-24.pdf
- [D5] /wp-json/wp/v2/pages/3778 (Judging and Evaluation, 2022-23 and 2023-24)
- [D6] /wp-json/wp/v2/pages/3768 (Deliverables, 2022-23 and 2023-24)
- [D8] /wp-json/wp/v2/pages/3782 (Previous Winners)
- [X1] https://www.scribd.com/document/938468063/Nonchalant-Neevites-1 (2025-26 Week 3 email; another team's upload that also holds its own portfolio notes, so only the email text is used)
- [X2] https://www.scribd.com/document/974710424/25-26-Week-Eight-Email

SMApply and platforms

- [S1] https://help.surveymonkey.com/en/apply/faqs/application-faq/
- [S2] https://wghsinvcomp.smapply.us/res/p/faqs/ (live FAQ: "for BOTH contributions, the IPS and Final Report")
- [ST1] https://www.stocktrak.com/terms-and-conditions/
- [GH1] https://docs.github.com/en/pull-requests/reference/forks (section "What happens to forks when a repository is deleted or changes visibility"; the older working-with-forks URL redirects here)
- [GD] https://developers.google.com/workspace/docs/api/how-tos/suggestions

Market data and funds

- [TSY] https://home.treasury.gov daily par yield curve CSV, 2026 (rows to 15 Oct; repo copy `caplet-latest/competition/official_market_data/daily-treasury-rates_2026-10.csv`)
- [I1] https://www.ishares.com/us/products/350028/ishares-ibonds-dec-2036-term-treasury-etf
- [I2] https://www.ishares.com/us/products/328944/ishares-ibonds-dec-2032-term-treasury-etf
- [I3] https://www.ishares.com/us/products/350212/ishares-ibonds-dec-2036-term-corporate-etf; iShares screener https://www.ishares.com/us/product-screener/product-screener-v3.1.jsn?dcrPath=/templatedata/config/product-screener-v3/data/en/us-ishares/ishares-product-screener-backend-config&siteEntryPassthrough=true
- [F1] https://fred.stlouisfed.org/graph/fredgraph.csv?id=BAMLC0A1CAAA,BAMLC0A2CAA
- [F2] https://fred.stlouisfed.org/graph/fredgraph.csv?id=DEXTAUS
- [FED] https://www.federalreserve.gov/monetarypolicy/fomccalendars.htm
- https://stockanalysis.com/etf/vt/ (VT fee 0.06%, 10,180 holdings)
- https://thewire.fiig.com.au/article/2026/07/15/attempting-to-quantify-the-risk-of-bonds-with-credit-ratings (secondary reproduction of S&P default data)

Co-sponsor and client evidence

- [K2] https://kresge.org/sites/default/files/GuidetoChallengeGrant.pdf (updated 30 Jun 2011)
- [B1] https://www.nature.com/articles/nclimate2194; https://link.springer.com/10.1038/nclimate2194
- [GE] https://www.chicagobooth.edu/review/dont-bother-doing-more-than-you-promised (cite the original paper in the Final Report)
- [V1] https://ideas.repec.org/p/van/wpaper/0008.html
- [L1] https://ideas.repec.org/a/eee/pubeco/v95y2011i5-6p351-362.html
- [SSIR] https://ssir.org/articles/entry/the_nonprofit_starvation_cycle
- [MOC] https://www.hccc.gov.tw/Utility/DisplayFile?id=7839 (Taiwan Ministry of Culture artist-village grant rules, 26 Jul 2019 text)
- [EY] https://www.dbas.taichung.gov.tw/media/280896/811511461738.pdf (Executive Yuan grant rules, 2016 text)
- [LG] https://lauragao.com/hey/

Other

- [K1] https://www.knox.nsw.edu.au/about/public-information/term-dates
- [NESA] https://www.nsw.gov.au/education-and-training/nesa/news/all/2026-hsc-timetables-released
- [MW] https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/root-and-branch
- [WP] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Interest_rate_cap_and_floor
- [CFA1] https://rpc.cfainstitute.org/-/media/documents/article/position-paper/investment-policy-statement-individual-investors.pdf
- [CFA2] https://rpc.cfainstitute.org/-/media/documents/code/amc/implementation-and-assessment-guide-june-2020.pdf
- Outside coverage [O1]-[O6] as listed in KB section 8 (Inklings News; Wharton LinkedIn; River Journal; Correio Braziliense; Westminster School; Brisbane State High).

Repo and scratchpad (read-only, 16 Oct 2026). Official files in `competition/official/2026_27/`; team files in `team/`; `COMPETITION.md`, `CLAUDE.md`, `START_HERE.md`, `docs/`, `rab/`, `research/insight_v1/`, `deliverables/`, `ops/routines/`; commit 412e9e3 files under `caplet-latest/`. Inputs to this report: `oct16/research/KB_what_wins.md`, `oct16/research/R1-R4*.md`, `oct16/lenses/*.md`, `oct16/verify/*_verify.md` and `*.final.json`. Earlier briefs: `scratchpad/oct14/final.md`, `oct14/tna_merge.md`, `oct14/ips_merge.md`, `scratchpad/REPORT.md`.

Appendix B. Verification log (what was refuted or adjusted, and why)

- **Refuted:** CLIENT-20. The early iBond rungs have the smallest 1-in-20 shortfall, not the largest (`oct16/verify/L02_client_forensic_verify.md:52`).
- **Partly refuted:**
  - COH-06: COMPETITION.md:70's note about the $150k is a fair reading of trading.txt:26.
  - COH-08: V5's $292,000 is dated, and it reproduces on the payment-date basis ($292,272 on 25 Sep).
  - JUDGE-07: the pitch claim does trace to team research; it overstates that research.
- **Adjusted, numbers:**
  - The 44-45% over-$300k odds mix bases; "about 1 in 3" holds only for the payment-date figure (STRAT-01, COH-01).
  - The sheet's 35% is anchored to $294k (`ips_numbers.py:122`).

    - The "1 in 3" chance that the floor is below $150k is `results.json` 0.352.
    - Word counts of the AI kit were inflated by hits on file paths and parts of words (COMM-06).
- **Adjusted, interpretation:**
    - $294.5k is what the holdings cost if waiting cash earns forward rates. It is not an arithmetic error (UNIQ-20, JUDGE-08).
    - The IPS does send sources to the Final Report, so credit for AI is late, not missing. The real problem is authorship and voice (INT-01, JUDGE-02).
    - "The team has not read the memos" is out of date; a 1 Oct team decision is recorded (`final_report.md:21`; TP-01).
    - A staff day means staff are at school but students are not (FR-01).
    - The only clear miss from the 15 Oct list is item 2; most items were not yet due (PM-08).
- **Dropped as uncalibrated AI opinion:** the rank band, numeric scorecard averages and the pre-mortem story odds (JUDGE-01; L12).

Appendix C. UNVERIFIED

- The TNA's weight in Top 50 selection.
- Wharton's SMApply submit flow.
- The "required trading activity" rule.
- Whether WInS history stays accessible after the season.
- The 2026-27 Final Report page range and sections; whether cash is allowed in the plan.
- The 2026-27 semifinal format; whether Laura attends the finale.
- The "at most half" volume rule; whether Stock-Trak's robot ban binds the Wharton edition.
- iBond distribution amounts after the freeze; whether WInS pays the May-2038 coupon on 15 Nov.
- A 2027 edition of J.P. Morgan's long-term capital market assumptions (none found).
- Whether the 16 Oct suggestions were placed in the Google Doc.
- Whether any member sits the HSC; whether one advisor serves all four Knox teams.
- Whether GitHub search surfaces the repo; whether a 2023 amendment changed the Taiwan grant rules.
- Whether Taiwan was sampled in the "17 languages" study; who wrote the 27 Sep "student-authored" notes.
- The current US credit ratings (check on the day before quoting any); the Moody's 2025 downgrade (primary source not opened).
- Whether WInS lists IBDX, IBDY, IBDZ, IBCA or IBCB.